

How successful is the author Khushwant Singh in showing the readers how external factors go a long way in shaping our National identity?

Train to Pakistan

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Introduction

If no mental activity changed the brain, we would still be living with the apes. The same applies to identity, which is constantly in flux vis-à-vis the outside world. We humans are highly social animals – tribalism has existed since the dawn of humanity. Our minds have evolved and are anchored to form and depend on social groups. From an evolutionary aspect, we've *needed* to form communities to survive, and over time, our communities have inadvertently molded our identities. What happens, then, when they *become* our identities? In *Train to Pakistan*, Author Kushwant Singh describes how National identity is not homogeneous, but shaped by fragmented individual perception. Our faiths can unite us just as well as they tear us apart. Our shared experiences can foster the human inside of us just as well as kill it. And it is exactly the differences in circumstance that lead to our riven identities. Life is a bundle of metaphors, and the story of Mano Majra is an allegory of the Indian experience before and during Partition.

How had religious intolerance torn apart the Indian National identity?

“If we have no faith in god then we are like animals.” Said the Muslim gravely. Religion had been the main institution for promoting social cooperation, morals, and ethical behaviour in India before and throughout partition. It would be the greatest irony, then, if it had caused the exact opposite – moral turmoil and complete disregard for human life. What difference do we have from animals, if we slaughter and ravage our own kind in merciless, unruly, perverted preservation of our own social identity?

The premise of the chaos across India in the summer of 1947 seems simple in retrospect. Uprisings were initially due to a political dispute between Mahatma Gandhi and Muhammad Ali Jinnah, which eventually led to the formation of a Muslim Pakistan and a Hindu India. People had to abandon their homes and communities to flee to their allocated countries, leading to increased civil unrest. Still, it would seem illogical that there would be much barbarity, seeing that people had been living rather peacefully just a few months prior to the British walking out of India. How could it be, then, that inter-communal violence led to the deaths of an estimated 200,000 to 2 million casualties?

Public disorder had led to dissent between religions. Smaller, cross-religion disputes quickly snowballed into larger riots, feeding an air of religious intolerance, which had been greatly exacerbated by the narrative that Hindus and Muslims were wholly incompatible in terms of political interests, lifestyle, and moral composition. Hundreds of thousands of Hindus and Sikhs fled towards the protection of predominantly Sikh and Hindu communities in the east on foot, in bullock carts, and even crammed into lorries and trains. Similarly, anxious swarms of Muslims were fleeing to safety in the West. It was inevitable that the two groups would collide. After all, ten million people were in flight.

Khushwant Singh described it best: ‘The riots had become a rout.’ All of Northern India was in terror, shrouded in confusion. For thousands, if not millions, the line between right or wrong was starting to blur, if it was not already snapped. Both sides killed and both sides died. It was a perpetuating cycle of fear and anxiety.

Describing the riots as a ‘rout’ suggests that the killings were deliberate. A conversation between police officers, who sat behind a crumbling law and order system, covered the emergence of trains filled to the brim with corpses being sent across the border to both India and Pakistan, by Sikhs and Muslims. In retaliation against convoys of Sikh corpses, the Sikhs in India had attacked a Muslim refugee train and sent it over the border with over a thousand corpses. But what truly captured the emotional landscape behind all this violence was the fact that on the train engine, the words ‘Gift to Pakistan’ were written in bold. This was not just a proclamation of war, for it highlighted a much more critical undertone – India’s National identity had already

been split into 'India' and 'Pakistan', into 'Sikh' and 'Muslim'. Demeaning the dead as a "gift" to Pakistan turned slaughter into spectacle. Sikhs who killed Muslims were seen as servicing their country, and it was the same for the latter.

In *Karma*, we see the final shred of respect for human dignity descend into an endless pit of hate. The revenge rhetoric had finally spread to Mano Majra. This is evident in the speech by the young Sikh boy, who declared boldly, "For each Hindu or Sikh they kill, kill two Mussulmans ... For each trainload of dead they send over, send two across..." The killing of Muslims had been justified and was seen as an irreproachable duty that all Sikhs carried. The boy continued on to proclaim that such deeds would stop the killings of Sikhs by the other side, providing the villagers even more incentive for violence. The rebuttals from Meet Singh were only met with even stronger revenge rhetoric.

Khushwant Singh uses the boy and his speech (pg. 145) as an ironic metaphor to describe the complete and utter loss of social law and religious norm in Mano Majra. In a town where the elders' words carried unquestioned authority, a young boy was preaching a mass massacre of their very own Muslim neighbours in the Gurdwara, while elders looked up and *listened*. Earlier, in *Kalyug*, a father had sternly reprimanded his son (pg. 81), described as a 'young villager' for speaking up in the presence of elders. Now, it was not a young villager who had spoken up in skepticism, but a *boy* who was edging his elders to throw away their humanity. Before, the comments and prayers of Imam Baksh and Meet Singh, the two religious leaders of their respective Muslim and Sikh communities, were met with silence punctuated by yawns and murmurs of 'Ya Allah' and 'Hey Wah Guru'. Several people even went to sleep.

Yet in *Karma*, the boy's speech had convinced more than fifty people to play a hand in killing their neighbours. And it was Meet Singh who had resigned to the boy in undisputed defeat, who humbly allowed the boy to lead in prayer. And this time, the entire assembly of women, children, men, and elders knelt and rubbed their foreheads on the ground, and, led by the young boy, chanted in unison that in the name of the Nanak and by the Grace of God, the Sikhs would rule and their enemies would be scattered. The ceremony ended with calls of victory, and all were sat except for the boy leader.

Ironically, the same religion that was meant to uphold social norm and encourage moral dignity led to the crumbling of both. Khushwant Singh uses such irony to describe the arrant desecration of National identity and moral practice during Partition, fed by religious intolerance and extremism.

Police officers appear frequently throughout *Train to Pakistan*. Ironically, not one police officer was portrayed as helpful in any way – if not corrupt, they were complacent. Hukum Chand's twisted rationale spurred his manipulation of arrests and releases, feeding revenge rhetoric in

Mano Majra. He meant no harm in doing so, of course. To him, he was only advocating for the quick dispatch of Muslim refugees to Pakistan. Khushwant Singh uses him and other officers as metaphors of political figures during Partition, who effectively enabled religious intolerance by either pushing a 'two-nation theory', or by being lax and ignorant.

How had normalisation and desensitization restructured individuals' sense of National identity?

In the summer of 1947 the goods train brought to Mano Majra many things. But most of all, it brought a sense of moral acclimation, coming in the form of thousands of Sikh and Hindu corpses. This was the turning point for all Mano Majrans.

The chapter *Mano Majra* marks the beginning of the shift in identity. Though the train of corpses was nowhere to be seen, the air of death was still present, as signaled by the presence of vultures and kites, who feasted on carrion. But the vultures and kites were not just a symbol of the death that had occurred. They foreshadowed the death that was coming. Later in *Karma*, the vultures and kites reappear with the arrival of a sea of corpses drifting down the river onto Mano Majra. Throughout the text, Author Khushwant Singh uses imagery of animals to reflect the inner turmoil of the residents of Mano Majra. Among these animals, snakes, dogs, and jackals serve as the most prominent metaphors of human behaviour in *Train to Pakistan*.

Early in the text, during a conversation about Jugga, Meet Singh declares that 'A snake can cast its slough but not its poison,' and asks Iqbal how long a snake could keep straight. This showed the Sikhs' belief that nobody could change their true nature, and that 'snakes' were treacherous through and through. There was crime in their blood.

Later on, this concept is brought up again through a youth's speech. Hukum Chand's dabbling had pushed the narrative that Muslims murdered Lala Ram Lal into the heads of the Sikhs. The youth explicitly states, 'They have behaved like snakes,' and this is met with fierce uproar. Equating the Muslims to snakes held grim consequences, for it was an immutable verdict of treason, and the Sikhs knew this well. Still, the boy continued to quote the stories of massacre from the Sikh refugees who had entered Mano Majra. Yet this was only the seed that had planted mistrust into the heads of the Singh – chaos was close, but it would not come yet.

Dogs' barks appear as a warning of threat at the start of *Train to Pakistan*. When Lala Ram Lal's home is raided by the dacoits, they bark to alert the rest of the villagers. The idea of dogs being signs of danger is also shown in Nooran's reaction, for she showed concern only after the silence that followed the gunshot was punctuated by the barking of dogs (pg. 19). Similarly, Hukum Chand was only alerted to the dacoity by the agitated barking of dogs (pg. 36). The villagers of Mano Majra use dog calls to identify danger, just like how they wake up to the sound of the goods train. This was all routine.

In *Karma*, a pack of Jackals howl after the sounds from the ghost train (pg. 139). This too was a warning, as seen in the Lambardar stating that they only howled after somebody's death. The Dogs and Jackals serve as an omen of doom. Yet, there is a stark difference in the reactions of

the villagers to their warnings. In *Dacoity*, villagers stayed in their homes and hid from the dacoity after hearing the dog barks. Whereas in *Karma*, the group of men, arguing to the lambardar that it was a human voice which he had heard, continued to watch the river in spite of nature's warning.

Khushwant Singh uses this animal imagery to describe how the villagers of Mano Majra had abandoned all reason. But more than that, he suggests that fear and horror had been institutionalised in Mano Majra, effectively reducing villagers to resort to primal instinct instead of rationale. Animals were attracted by the scent of death, and by the same token, death had attracted animalistic vengeance. The shared identity they once had – of being Mano Majrans, of coexisting with their Muslim neighbours, had been erased and replaced with feral human nature.

Karma begins with the startling rise of the river. This wasn't just a rise in a few centimetres – overnight, it fills up to the dam. This mirrors the sudden rise in the villagers' animosity towards the Muslims. The monsoon marks a turning point in Mano Majra. With it, as mentioned in the text, 'the tempo of life and death increases'. Swept in by the Monsoon, refugees start pouring into Mano Majra, and Trains filled with the dead become increasingly frequent. Monsoon showers 'start and stop without warning'. Villagers are forced to face the chaos of partition head-on, as seen in the sudden arrival of the Train filled with corpses, the refugees' arrival, and the Muslims' evacuating the town. The monsoon marks a season of change, and the river swells with its showers, carrying debris and bodies. This time, it is violence and hate muddying the waters, and the monsoon acts as a metaphor for the creeping, yet unpredictable and absurd nature of violence. And with it, the river, the Town's lifeblood, which connects it to the wider world both literally and figuratively, becomes a symbol of Moral decay slowly creeping up on the villagers.

'There was no doubt in anyone's mind what the train contained.' The Train used to be the pulse of the village, but later on became a hearse, a symbol of death. The sound of its engine, once a comforting sound, now invited fear. The routine that Mano Majrans were used to becomes disrupted with the train coming at random times, mimicking the social disarray that Mano Majra was going through. With the tempo of the village gone, fear and violence becoming routine, and the harmony in Mano Majra collapsing, chaos became normalised. Sikhs had become desensitized to violence, and religious norms crumbled, as seen in the Gurdwara moving from a place of worship to a conclave where villagers conspired to massacre the Muslims. This also mirrored how religious institutions across India became political platforms during Partition, sometimes sanctifying violence in the name of vengeance.

'Everyone has gone trigger-happy.' (pg. 151)

Villagers, adapting to the rampant chaos that slowly swept into Mano Majra, had become desensitized to the very concept of violence. Routine and social structure collapsed. Normalisation reduced everyone to animals. Any sort of communal identity had been desecrated and replaced by separate religion-based national identities that glorified violence as justified vengeance.

How have external influences and a difference in circumstance led to the development of a fractured Indian National identity?

“The human being is a self-propelled automaton entirely under the control of external influences. Willful and predetermined though they appear, his actions are governed not from within, but from without. He is like a float tossed about by the waves of a turbulent sea.” The human being Nikola Tesla describes in his statement is not the one in physical form, but the immaterial identity that resides within all of us.

India was a people, a people who had been ruled over by the British for close to a century. The Indians who gained independence were not the same as the Indians who pledged allegiance to local rulers, whose identity was lived in the dialect they spoke, in the spices they ground, and the festivals they prepared months in advance. They were not Indians who had all been united as one nation under the leadership of Gandhi. It wasn't that they were against him. Unity and harmony just seemed distant to a people who had endured years of oppression and exploitation from the British. They were Indians who had been politicised, who thought of themselves as a nation, albeit through hardened religious and caste divisions.

Mano Majra was an outlier. Across India, even during partition, there were rural villages that had not even learnt of the British leaving, who lived peacefully in their own gated communities, who welcomed all regardless of religion. Mano Majra was one of them. Early on, the police subinspector notes that ‘no one in Mano Majra even knows that the British have left and the country is divided into Pakistan and Hindustan.’

Yet its story was a story of change. Residents went from paying their rent to Lala Ram Lal dutifully and living in harmony, to hating and conspiring to kill their very own neighbours. These quick developments reflected events during partition.

During colonial rule, the British divided India across religious lines, particularly by creating separate voter lists for Muslims and Hindus, to solidify political dynamics. They introduced separate electorates for Muslims and Hindus, which fortified communal identities and religious division. Sure, Muslims and Hindus had their differences even before British rule, but there was no animosity between them, up till 1857.

Khushwant Singh never really delves into the British Raj and its meddlings in India. They are portrayed as more of a shadow that overlooked the whole of the country. The first mention of the British suggests that their absence was the primary cause of division. This ironic rhetoric carries forward into the rest of the text, in comparisons of the ‘English’ to the police, Indian politicians, and educated Indians. The second mention of the British presents the irony that Indians were better off under the British, for at the very least law was upheld. It is absurd that colonial

oppression becomes recast as stability once independence delivers chaos – the British themselves had committed many atrocities, including massacres like the one in Amritsar.

Hukum Chand is the police magistrate of Mano Majra. More than that, he's an apostle of colonialism, an aloof and cynical officer like many others, and the lead metaphor Khuswant Singh uses to describe the effects of colonialism on India's National identity. On the surface, he is the main driver of religious division in Mano Majra and an enabler of violence, as mentioned before.

This is evident in his conversation with the police subinspector from Chundunnugger, a 'good' police station where corruption is widespread. The subinspector displays his cynicism by stating that the Sikhs had lost their manliness in allowing Muslims to conduct prayer in border villages like Mano Majra, rationalising that they were getting money from the Muslims. He continues his rant about the corrupt government, but is interrupted by Hukum Chand, who places a hand on his knee (pg. 26). This emphasises his tendency to control and manipulate, which is later seen in him choosing to push the narrative that the Muslims had betrayed the Sikhs by portraying Iqbal as a Muslim leaguer, and telling the Sikhs that the Muslims had killed Lala Ram Lal.

Hukum Chand likens the subinspector to a child, and states that 'your principle should be to see everything and say nothing', and 'even if you feel strongly about something, learn to keep silent'. This highlights his indifference to the plight of the Mano Majrans, instead relying on his twisted instinct to force division on religious lines in the name of justice. His cynicism in calling order a fiction contrasts with British ideologies, yet his presence splits Mano Majra religiously, replicating the effects of colonial influence on India.

'Freedom is for the educated people who fought for it.' When a Muslim villager says this to Iqbal (pg. 51), his reaction is nothing short of hypocritical – to him it was simple, social progress simply depended on the villager's votes. He labels himself as a social worker, referring to the villagers as 'backward', and uses a humble yet patronising tone when addressing them. This contrasts with his attitude towards police officers, where he takes on a more haughty tone.

After his talk with the Muslim villager, Khushwant Singh described his thoughts: 'All that could be done was to divert the kill-and-grab instinct from communal channels and turn it against the propertied class. That was the proletariat revolution the easy way. His party bosses would not see it.' Khushwant Singh uses this style of writing, describing Iqbal's thoughts from an outsider's point of view, to stress how utterly detached he is. His obsession with political reform displays how his education alienates him from the chaotic reality villagers faced. Singh builds an adamant wall between educated Indians and the common peasant – their difference in socioeconomic class and experiences leads to a stark contrast in perception. Their identities as Indians are fundamentally different.

On the opposite side of the coin, Jugga is portrayed as an unpolished, uneducated, and churlish thug. The text repeatedly emphasises that he is a badmash. Yet in the end, his daredevil act saves the lives of the Muslims on the train – his pure love for Nooran and his village outshines Iqbal's reformist ideals. Earlier in the text, during Meet Singh and Iqbal's conversation about Jugga, both agree that he is a criminal who will never change, like a snake who can never shed its poison, though Iqbal blames hunger, want, and injustice as causes of his behaviour.

It's acts like these that keep India's soul intact. The irony is that while educated Indians control the population, it is the common peasant who truly embodies the nation's spirit – one of religious coexistence. Iqbal presents himself as a representative of India due to his higher education; yet in the end it is Jugga, the badmash, who truly displays patriotism.

Singh's clues and his use of ironic rhetoric lead to a brutal revelation. Elites perpetuated division by pushing politics as an answer, carrying forward British control tactics. But it was the commoners who held the nation's soul, rooted in a love for their community, not politics. Indian elites fractured the Indian identity by prioritizing British logic. This is classic Stockholm syndrome. An English education leads to an English mind, and what is the difference between English-educated Indians and the British controlling India?

The National identity that resided within the hearts of Indian elites and Indian commoners was inherently different. It was precisely the difference in their socioeconomic status, education, and external influences that led to the formation of a fractured Indian National identity.

Conclusion

At the beginning of *Train to Pakistan*, the residents of Mano Majira – Muslims, Sikhs, and Lala Ram Lal alike, lived in harmony. Partition was the systematic ravaging of social structure, the final push towards the breaking point for all Indians. Once the already-fractured National identity that had held under British Colonial rule was rejected, chaos ensued. It spread across the country, that there could never be a completely Hindi India or a completely Muslim India without expelling the other.

In my introduction, I talked about communities taking over our identities. I argue that the National identity Kushwant Singh describes in *Train to Pakistan* is not one of unity, but one grounded in religious nationalism, one that legitimized violence, one that was socially fractured and hammered into shape by the overhanging weight of British colonialism.

Personal ethics should never be compromised, especially by religious beliefs when they encourage violence. Without moral fortitude, the Sikhs and Muslims in *Train to Pakistan* became comparable to hyperevangelistic chimps with no qualms about killing. As Gandhi said, ‘Be the change you wish to see in the world.’ The reality of partition that Khushwant Singh describes may have been grim, but it was not without hope. There is still capacity for change.

To conclude, I pose the question: *Can India’s identity mend, post-fracture?*

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